

HIPPOPOTAMUSES



SPENDING THE DAY submerged in water, hippopotamuses emerge at dusk to feed on nearby grasslands. Well-used pathways lead to their feeding grounds. There are two species of hippo – the common hippo and the pygmy hippo – both of which live in the equatorial regions of Africa. The common hippo is the third largest land animal after the elephant and the white rhino. Common hippos have a huge appetite and can consume vast quantities of grass. In places where they are numerous, they may destroy the vegetation for a considerable distance from the river or lake in which they live, sometimes causing serious soil erosion.



School of hippos

The common hippo lives in groups of 20–100 animals called schools. A school spends the day partly submerged in water or wallowing in mud pools. Hippos establish a territory with males around the edge, and females and young in the centre. Males are excluded from the female area except in the breeding season. Any male approaching too close will be attacked by the females.

Young

Thirty-four weeks after mating, the female gives birth to a single young. Birth normally takes place on land, but occasionally in water. The newborn hippo can swim, walk, and run within a few minutes of being born. If a female temporarily leaves the territory, she puts her calf in the care of another female.



Pygmy hippopotamus

The pygmy hippo is about one-fifth the size of the common hippo. It swims well, but is less aquatic than the common hippo. It lives in marshland and swamp forest where it makes tunnel-like tracks through the undergrowth. If alarmed it seeks refuge in dense undergrowth. The pygmy hippo is a shy, nocturnal animal living alone or in pairs. It spends most of the day resting and feeds during darkness on swamp plants, fruit, and leaves.

Round head and body



Thick skin

Common hippopotamus

The common hippo is a very large and aggressive animal. It is the second heaviest land animal after the elephant. Despite its huge size and legs that seem too short for its enormous barrel-like body, it can move at surprising speed. Anything coming between it and the water is liable to be attacked. Hippos make a variety of noises from bellowing to snorting.

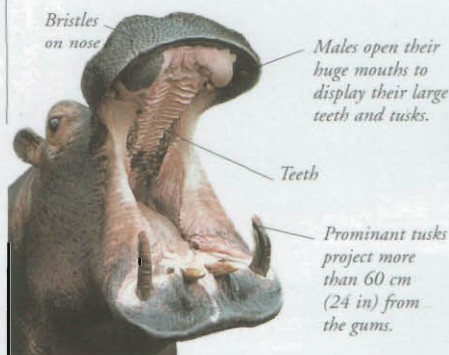
Scars are usually the result of sparring between adult males.



Small ears

Hippos feed on grass.

Bristles on nose



Males open their huge mouths to display their large teeth and tusks.

Teeth

Prominent tusks project more than 60 cm (24 in) from the gums.

Threat displays

Males challenge each other by opening their mouths to maximum gape. If this fails to deter a rival, they may rise up out of the water and try to slash each other with their tusks. Ferocious fights often develop between rival males and may lead to serious injury.

Eyes, ears, and nostrils appear above the water surface.



Hippos spend up to 18 hours a day submerged in water.

Hippo underwater

The common hippo, whose name means "river horse", is more at home in water than on land. When submerged it can hold its breath and seal its nostrils and ears. Normally, it stays underwater for 3–5 minutes before having to surface to breathe, but, if necessary, it can remain submerged for considerably longer. It swims easily and may walk along the bottom of the riverbed.

Hippo walking on the bottom of a riverbed.



COMMON HIPPOPOTAMUS

SCIENTIFIC NAME *Hippopotamus amphibius*

ORDER Artiodactyla

FAMILY Hippopotamidae

DISTRIBUTION Tropical Africa

HABITAT Rivers, lakes, and estuaries

DIET Grass and aquatic vegetation – up to 45 kg (100 lb) per day

SIZE Height: 1.52 m (5 ft); weight: 4.06 tonnes (4 tons)

LIFESPAN 50 years

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